After a city removes library fines, the outstanding debt disappears, so apparent improvement in account balances says nothing about whether books come back sooner. Measure days overdue among loans issued after the change instead. Compare the same calendar weeks with a neighbouring council that keeps its old rules, because school holidays can alter borrowing. Keep replacement charges unchanged during the experiment so the policy contrast is interpretable. Success means shorter delays in returning books without fewer loans to residents who previously owed money.